REGTECH · WEALTHTECH

WORK RECORD · REC-02

Designing a product that is not allowed to decide.

An investment advisory platform built under an ADGM Category 4 licence, where the regulation was not a checklist at the end. It was the product spec.

HIGH-LEVEL OVERVIEW

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THE PROBLEM

A licensed advisor, not a robo-advisor.

Belvro Wealth recommends model portfolios to retail investors. The investor sees the recommendation, and the investor decides.

Two things the platform **never** does: it never executes a trade the client has not explicitly approved, and it never holds, touches, or moves client money. Both are licence conditions — and both had to be **visible in the interface**, not just true in the backend.

I was brought in to define the product. What follows is the reasoning behind the specification, kept deliberately at the level of decisions rather than detail.

What I defined

SCOPE	CORE FLOW	COMMERCIAL
Product spec suite	**Approval & audit**	**Fee & billing model**

THE CONSTRAINT

One word separates two businesses.

An advisory licence and a discretionary-management licence describe products that look almost identical on screen. The line between them is **approval**.

IF THE SYSTEM ACTS

It is managing money. Different licence, different capital requirements, different company.

IF THE CLIENT ACTS

It is advising and arranging. Which is the business we were licensed to be.

So the design question was never “how do we stay compliant?” It was: **how do we make it structurally impossible for the system to act on its own** — and how do we prove that later, to a regulator, on demand?

FOUR DECISIONS

What I specified, and why.

1 · Approval is per trade, never per basket

A single “approve all” button would have been better UX and a worse product. Every recommendation is confirmed individually.

2 · The audit trail is a feature, not a log

What was recommended, when it was shown, when it was approved, and what the client rejected — specified as first-class product data, not engineering exhaust.

3 · Fees live entirely outside the investment account

Billing was specified as a separate rail. Cleaner for the client to read, and it keeps the licence boundary intact by construction.

4 · Many strategies from day one

Building around a single flagship strategy would have been faster to ship and expensive to undo. The model was specified as one of many from the first version.

THE CALL I'D DEFEND

I specified per-trade approval knowing it costs conversion.

Every extra confirmation loses users. The commercial argument for bulk approval was real, and I understood it. But that friction **is** the product. It is the thing that makes the client the decision-maker, and it is the only reason the company can operate under the licence it holds.

What I took from it

In a regulated product, compliance is not a stage gate you clear before launch. It is the shape of the thing you are building. The earlier a PM treats it as design input instead of design tax, the better the product gets.

Happy to talk through the thinking —
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